COMPREHENSIVE POLITICAL THEORY

Detailed Exam-Oriented Notes
Definitions • Explanations • Thinkers • Examples • Comparisons • Likely Exam Questions

Purpose of this study guide

These notes are designed for introductory and undergraduate political theory courses. They combine conceptual explanations with major thinkers and theories, while highlighting points that are useful when answering examinations.

How to use the notes

Read the definition first, understand the argument, learn the key terms, compare competing thinkers, and practise the questions at the end of each topic. For essays, use the structure: introduction → definitions → arguments → examples → criticism → conclusion.

1. INTRODUCTION TO POLITICAL THEORY

Meaning of political theory

Political theory is the systematic study of political ideas, values, concepts, institutions and arguments. It asks what political life ought to be like as well as how political arrangements work. Typical questions include: What is justice? What makes government legitimate? What is freedom? Why should citizens obey the law? Who should rule?

Political theory and political science

Political science is the broader systematic study of politics. Political theory is one of its major branches and concentrates especially on concepts, arguments, values and normative questions. Political theory can use history, philosophy, law and social science evidence.

Normative and empirical approaches

Normative theory asks what ought to be the case and evaluates political institutions using standards such as justice, equality or liberty. Empirical approaches ask what actually happens and seek evidence about political behaviour and institutions. The two can complement one another.

Importance of political theory

It clarifies concepts; evaluates political institutions; exposes assumptions behind political arguments; provides standards for judging government; helps citizens think critically; and connects political practice to ideas about justice and human flourishing.

Key terms

Politics: activities involving power and collective decision-making. Ideology: an organised set of political ideas and values. Institution: an established structure or practice governing social behaviour. Legitimacy: the perceived rightfulness of political authority. Liberty: a condition of freedom. Equality: equal status, rights, opportunities or distribution depending on the context.

2. THE STATE, GOVERNMENT AND SOVEREIGNTY

Meaning of the state

A state is a politically organised community exercising authority over a defined territory and population. The classic elements are population, territory, government and sovereignty.

State versus government

The state is the enduring political entity; government refers to the institutions and office-holders through which state authority is exercised. Governments can change while the state continues.

Sovereignty

Sovereignty means supreme political authority. Internal sovereignty concerns authority within a territory; external sovereignty concerns independence from outside political control.

Austin's theory

John Austin described sovereignty in terms of a determinate human superior whose commands are habitually obeyed. The theory is influential but criticised for difficulty explaining constitutional limits, divided sovereignty and democratic authority.

Modern constitutionalism

Modern states commonly limit public power through constitutions, separation of powers, courts, elections, bills of rights and accountability institutions.

Example

A constitution may give parliament law-making powers while courts review whether laws comply with constitutional rights. This demonstrates that public authority is structured and limited rather than simply unlimited.

3. POWER, AUTHORITY AND LEGITIMACY

Power

Power is the capacity to influence behaviour, decisions or outcomes. It may involve coercion, persuasion, control of resources, agenda-setting or shaping beliefs.

Authority

Authority is power regarded as rightful or legitimate. A police officer enforcing a lawful court order exercises authority; an armed criminal may have power but lacks legitimate authority.

Weber's three types

Max Weber identified traditional authority, based on established custom; charismatic authority, based on devotion to an exceptional leader; and legal-rational authority, based on rules and offices.

Legitimacy

Legitimacy concerns why people accept political rule as rightful. Sources may include constitutional procedures, elections, tradition, performance, consent and justice.

Why legitimacy matters

A government relying only on coercion may be unstable and costly to maintain. Legitimacy encourages voluntary compliance and supports political stability.

Likely distinction

Power answers 'Can this actor influence others?' Authority asks 'Is that power recognised as rightful?' Legitimacy asks 'Why is the rule or authority justified or accepted?'

4. PLATO AND THE IDEAL STATE

Plato's background

Plato developed political ideas in response to questions about justice, knowledge and good leadership. His major political work is The Republic.

Justice

Plato presents justice as a form of harmony in which each part performs its appropriate function. He connects individual psychology with the organisation of the state.

Three classes

His ideal state contains rulers, auxiliaries and producers. Rulers govern, auxiliaries defend the community, and producers provide economic goods.

Philosopher-kings

Plato argues that those who possess philosophical knowledge should rule. The ruler should pursue the common good rather than personal wealth or status.

Education

Education is essential for identifying and preparing suitable rulers. Political leadership therefore requires knowledge, discipline and moral formation.

Criticism

Critics argue that philosopher-rule can be elitist, difficult to implement and insufficiently democratic. Others question who determines who is truly wise.

5. ARISTOTLE AND POLITICAL COMMUNITY

Political animal

Aristotle argued that human beings are naturally political because they develop their capacities within a political community.

Purpose of the polis

The political community exists not merely for survival but for a good life. Political institutions should therefore contribute to human flourishing.

Classification of constitutions

Aristotle classified constitutions according to whether rule serves the common good or the rulers' private interests. Rule by one, few or many can be good or corrupt depending on purpose.

Middle class

He regarded a strong middle class as important for stability because extreme wealth and poverty can produce conflict.

Comparison with Plato

Plato constructs a more idealised political order; Aristotle pays greater attention to actual constitutions, political experience and practical institutional design.

6. HOBBES AND THE SOCIAL CONTRACT

State of nature

Thomas Hobbes imagines a condition without a common political authority. Because people are vulnerable and compete for security and resources, life can become insecure and conflict-prone.

Social contract

Individuals agree to establish a sovereign authority capable of maintaining peace. Political authority is justified largely by the need for security.

Strong sovereignty

Hobbes favours powerful sovereign authority because divided or weak authority can return society to disorder.

Freedom

For Hobbes, freedom is closely connected to the absence of external impediments. Political order limits some actions but makes secure social life possible.

Criticism

Critics argue that Hobbes underestimates cooperation and risks justifying excessive state power. Supporters emphasise his realistic concern with insecurity and political disorder.

7. LOCKE, NATURAL RIGHTS AND LIMITED GOVERNMENT

Natural rights

John Locke argues that individuals possess natural rights, especially life, liberty and property. These rights do not originate merely from government.

Consent

Legitimate government depends on the consent of the governed. Government is a trust established to protect rights.

Right of resistance

If government systematically violates the purposes for which it was established, people may resist or replace it.

Property

Locke connects property to labour and argues that individuals can acquire property under conditions. His theory became influential in liberal constitutionalism.

Influence

Lockean ideas influenced modern constitutional government, limited government and rights-based political thought.

Criticism

Questions arise over how universal the theory's conception of property and consent is, and whether historical inequalities fit neatly with its assumptions.

8. ROUSSEAU AND THE GENERAL WILL

Critique of inequality

Jean-Jacques Rousseau examines how social development and unequal property relations can undermine freedom and civic equality.

Social contract

Legitimate political association occurs when people collectively constitute themselves as a sovereign people.

General will

The general will represents the common interest of the political community. It is not simply the sum of private preferences.

Popular sovereignty

The people are the ultimate source of legitimate political authority. Political freedom involves participation in collective self-government.

Criticism

The general will can be difficult to distinguish from the will claimed by a majority or political elite. Critics worry that it can be used to justify coercion in the name of collective freedom.

9. LIBERALISM

Definition

Liberalism is a family of political theories emphasising individual liberty, rights, consent, constitutionalism, tolerance and limits on arbitrary power.

Classical liberalism

Classical liberalism generally supports limited government, private property, freedom of contract and protection from excessive state interference.

Modern liberalism

Modern liberal approaches may support public action to provide education, healthcare, social security or other conditions that make meaningful freedom possible.

Mill and liberty

John Stuart Mill defended individual freedom and argued that interference with a person's liberty generally requires a strong justification, especially the prevention of harm to others.

Criticisms

Communitarian critics argue that liberalism can exaggerate individual independence. Socialist critics question whether formal liberty is meaningful amid severe economic inequality.

10. MARXISM AND CLASS STRUGGLE

Historical materialism

Karl Marx explains social and political development partly through material production and relations between classes.

Classes under capitalism

The bourgeoisie control major productive resources while workers sell their labour. Marx argues that capitalist relations generate exploitation and class conflict.

Alienation

Workers may become separated from the products of labour, the process of work, their human potential and other people.

The state

Marxist theory often views the state in relation to class power and economic structures, although later Marxists developed more complex accounts of state autonomy.

Revolution

Class consciousness and conflict can contribute to transformation of capitalist relations.

Criticism

Critics argue that Marx underestimated the adaptability of capitalism, the importance of democratic institutions and identities other than class. Marxist theory nevertheless remains influential in analysing inequality and economic power.

11. DEMOCRACY

Definition

Democracy is government in which political authority is ultimately connected to the people.

Direct and representative democracy

Direct democracy involves citizens deciding issues themselves; representative democracy involves elected officials making decisions on behalf of citizens.

Core principles

Political equality, participation, competitive elections, accountability, rule of law, protection of rights and peaceful transfer of power.

Majority rule and minority rights

Democracy cannot be reduced to majority rule. Constitutional rights protect minorities from arbitrary or permanent domination.

Challenges

Corruption, misinformation, political exclusion, unequal resources, voter apathy, authoritarian tendencies and weak institutions can undermine democratic quality.

Example

An election alone does not guarantee democracy if opposition parties cannot campaign freely, courts are controlled by the executive, or citizens cannot express criticism without intimidation.

12. REPRESENTATION AND POLITICAL PARTIES

Meaning of representation

Representation is the process by which political actors act on behalf of citizens.

Delegate and trustee models

A delegate follows constituents' preferences closely. A trustee uses personal judgment while considering the public interest.

Political parties

Parties organise political competition, recruit candidates, develop programmes, mobilise voters and structure government and opposition.

Accountability

Elections provide one mechanism of accountability. Others include legislative oversight, courts, media, civil society and public participation.

Representation challenges

Some groups may be underrepresented because of wealth, gender, age, geography, disability, social exclusion or electoral rules.

13. JUSTICE

Meaning

Justice concerns fairness in the distribution of benefits and burdens and in the treatment of persons.

Distributive justice

Asks how resources, opportunities and social advantages should be allocated.

Procedural justice

Focuses on whether decision-making processes are fair, impartial, transparent and consistent.

Rawls

John Rawls's theory of justice as fairness begins with an imagined original position in which parties choose principles without knowing their own social position. His theory emphasises equal basic liberties, fair equality of

opportunity and the difference principle.

Nozick

Robert Nozick defends an entitlement approach focused on just acquisition, just transfer and rectification rather than a patterned distribution.

Debate

Rawls asks whether social institutions are fair to the least advantaged; Nozick stresses individual rights and legitimate holdings. The debate illustrates different understandings of distributive justice.

14. EQUALITY

Forms of equality

Equality can mean equality before the law, political equality, equality of opportunity, equality of resources or equality of outcomes.

Formal versus substantive equality

Formal equality treats people according to the same rule. Substantive equality considers whether apparently equal rules produce persistent disadvantage and may support corrective measures.

Equality and merit

A merit-based system may reward performance, but political theory asks whether people begin with genuinely fair opportunities.

Arguments for equality

Equality may promote dignity, political inclusion, social stability and fair opportunity.

Arguments against extensive redistribution

Critics argue that excessive redistribution can interfere with liberty, incentives or legitimate property rights. The debate depends on the conception of equality being defended.

15. FREEDOM AND LIBERTY

Negative liberty

Freedom from interference by other people or institutions.

Positive liberty

Freedom understood as the capacity or conditions enabling people to develop and participate effectively.

Mill

Mill argues for broad individual liberty and a presumption against paternalistic interference, while recognising the importance of preventing harm to others.

Limits of liberty

Freedom is not unlimited. Political communities may restrict conduct to protect others' rights, public order or legitimate public interests, subject to legal and constitutional standards.

Exam distinction

Do not treat negative liberty as 'good' and positive liberty as 'bad'. They answer different questions about what it means to be free.

16. AUTHORITY, OBLIGATION AND CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE

Political obligation

Political obligation asks why citizens have duties to obey political authority and laws.

Consent theory

One argument is that citizens are bound because they consent to political arrangements. Critics note that explicit consent is rare and implied consent may be difficult to establish.

Fair play

Another argument holds that those who benefit from a cooperative system have duties to support it under fair conditions.

Civil disobedience

Civil disobedience is a deliberate violation of law, usually public and non-violent, aimed at addressing serious injustice. It raises questions about when obedience should yield to conscience.

Key issue

A strong essay should distinguish disagreement with a policy from principled civil disobedience and consider proportionality, publicity, non-violence and respect for rights.

17. FEMINIST POLITICAL THEORY

Definition

Feminist political theory analyses political power through gender and challenges institutions and concepts that reproduce gender inequality.

The public/private divide

Feminist thinkers argue that matters traditionally labelled 'private', such as household labour, caregiving and family power, can have major political consequences.

Liberal feminism

Emphasises equal rights, opportunities, education and removal of discriminatory barriers.

Radical feminism

Focuses strongly on structures of patriarchy and forms of domination embedded in social and sexual relations.

Socialist feminism

Connects gender inequality with economic structures, labour and capitalism.

Intersectionality

Intersectional approaches examine how gender can interact with class, race, ethnicity, disability and other social positions to produce different experiences of power and disadvantage.

18. NATIONALISM

Definition

Nationalism gives political importance to the nation and often supports national self-determination.

Civic and ethnic nationalism

Civic nationalism emphasises shared citizenship and political institutions. Ethnic nationalism places greater emphasis on ancestry, culture or ethnic belonging.

Anti-colonial nationalism

Nationalism played a major role in struggles for independence by mobilising populations around self-rule and political sovereignty.

Benefits and risks

Nationalism can promote solidarity, independence and collective identity. It can also become exclusionary when membership is defined narrowly.

Self-determination

The principle holds that peoples should have meaningful control over their political status and collective future, although its application can conflict with territorial integrity and minority rights.

19. AFRICAN POLITICAL THOUGHT

Overview

African political thought is diverse and includes pre-colonial political traditions, anti-colonial thought, post-independence theories and contemporary debates about democracy, development and identity.

Kwame Nkrumah

Nkrumah connected Pan-Africanism with political and economic independence and developed the concept of neo-colonialism to describe indirect external influence after formal independence.

Julius Nyerere

Nyerere's Ujamaa emphasised community, collective responsibility and national development. Its practical implementation remains debated.

Frantz Fanon

Fanon analysed colonial domination, psychological effects of colonialism and anti-colonial struggle. His work links political liberation with questions of human dignity and social transformation.

Contemporary relevance

African political thought raises continuing questions about sovereignty, economic dependency, democratic institutions, citizenship, development and regional integration.

20. NATIONALISM, PAN-AFRICANISM AND POST-COLONIALISM

Pan-Africanism

Pan-Africanism promotes solidarity among African peoples and cooperation across colonial boundaries. It has political, cultural and economic dimensions.

Colonial legacy

Post-colonial political theory examines how colonial institutions, economic structures, identities and knowledge systems can continue to influence independent states.

Dependency and neo-colonialism

Dependency approaches focus on unequal economic relationships between wealthy and poorer regions. Neo-colonialism highlights forms of influence that may persist after formal political independence.

Political challenge

The central question is how states can achieve meaningful sovereignty while participating in a global economy and international institutions.

21. THE RULE OF LAW AND CONSTITUTIONALISM

Rule of law

The rule of law means that public power is exercised according to established law and that persons are protected against arbitrary government action.

Constitutionalism

Constitutionalism holds that government power should be limited and structured by a constitution or fundamental legal principles.

Separation of powers

Legislative, executive and judicial functions are distributed to reduce concentration of power.

Checks and balances

Institutions monitor and constrain one another. Examples include legislative oversight, judicial review and constitutional procedures.

Importance

Rule of law supports predictability, equality before law, protection of rights and accountable government.

22. RIGHTS AND CITIZENSHIP

Human and civil rights

Rights are justified claims or entitlements held by persons or groups. Civil rights include protections such as equality before law and freedoms of expression and association.

Political rights

Political rights include participation in public affairs, voting and eligibility for public office subject to lawful requirements.

Citizenship

Citizenship combines membership in a political community with rights and responsibilities.

Duties

Citizens may have duties to obey lawful rules, pay taxes where required, participate responsibly and respect the rights of others.

Rights conflicts

Rights may conflict in practice. Political theory asks how such conflicts should be balanced using principles of equality, liberty, harm, proportionality and constitutional law.

23. SEPARATION OF POWERS AND POLITICAL INSTITUTIONS

Legislature

Makes laws, represents citizens, debates public policy and exercises oversight.

Executive

Implements laws and directs public administration. In different systems it may be led by a president or prime minister.

Judiciary

Interprets law and resolves disputes. In constitutional systems courts may review government action.

Why separation matters

Concentrated power increases risks of abuse. Institutional division creates opportunities for oversight and correction.

Limits

Separation of powers does not mean complete isolation. Effective government requires cooperation as well as checks.

24. POLITICAL IDEOLOGIES

Conservatism

Emphasises tradition, social stability, institutional continuity and cautious change.

Socialism

Broadly prioritises social ownership, equality or collective control of productive resources, though socialist theories vary considerably.

Communism

In classical Marxist theory, communism is associated with a classless society and common ownership of productive resources.

Anarchism

Anarchist theories are generally critical of coercive hierarchical authority and explore forms of voluntary association and decentralised organisation.

Green political thought

Environmental political theory emphasises ecological sustainability, intergenerational justice and the political implications of environmental limits.

Exam advice

Always define the ideology before evaluating it, because each label contains multiple traditions.

25. GLOBAL JUSTICE AND HUMANITARIAN POLITICS

Global justice

Global justice asks whether principles of justice should apply beyond national borders and how responsibilities should be distributed internationally.

Key issues

Poverty, migration, climate change, global inequality, war, refugees and international institutions.

Cosmopolitanism

Cosmopolitan theories argue that moral concern should not stop at national borders.

Statist approaches

Statist views give greater weight to duties among citizens and the special obligations created by political communities.

Contemporary relevance

Global interdependence makes questions of responsibility, sovereignty and fairness increasingly important.

26. EXAM REVISION: KEY DEFINITIONS

Political theory: Systematic study and evaluation of political concepts, institutions, values and arguments.

State: A political community with population, territory, government and sovereignty.

Government: Institutions and office-holders through which political authority is exercised.

Sovereignty: Supreme political authority within a political community and independence from external control.

Power: Capacity to influence behaviour, decisions or outcomes.

Authority: Power recognised as rightful.

Legitimacy: Rightfulness or justified acceptance of political rule.

Justice: Fairness in treatment and distribution.

Equality: Equal status, rights, opportunities, resources or outcomes depending on the context.

Liberty: Freedom, understood as absence of interference and/or capacity for self-development.

Democracy: A system in which political authority is ultimately connected to the people.

Constitutionalism: The principle that government power should be limited and structured by constitutional rules.

Nationalism: Political emphasis on the nation and often on national self-determination.

Ideology: An organised set of political ideas and values.

Civil disobedience: Principled, deliberate violation of law, typically public and non-violent, to challenge serious injustice.

27. LIKELY SHORT-ANSWER QUESTIONS

1. Define political theory and explain two reasons for studying it.
2. Distinguish between the state and government.
3. State and explain the four elements of a state.
4. What is sovereignty? Distinguish internal from external sovereignty.
5. Differentiate power, authority and legitimacy.
6. Explain Weber's three types of legitimate authority.
7. What is Plato's concept of justice?
8. Who are Plato's philosopher-kings?
9. Explain Aristotle's idea that human beings are political animals.
10. What is the social contract?
11. State two differences between Hobbes and Locke.
12. Explain Locke's theory of natural rights.
13. What is Rousseau's general will?
14. Define liberalism.
15. Distinguish negative and positive liberty.
16. What is class struggle according to Marx?
17. Define alienation.
18. State five principles of democracy.
19. What is representative democracy?
20. Define distributive and procedural justice.

21. Explain Rawls's difference principle.
22. What is political obligation?
23. Define civil disobedience.
24. What is nationalism?
25. What is Pan-Africanism?
26. Explain the rule of law.
27. What is separation of powers?
28. Define constitutionalism.
29. Identify three feminist approaches to political theory.
30. Explain the difference between civic and ethnic nationalism.

28. LIKELY ESSAY QUESTIONS AND ANSWER GUIDES

Compare Hobbes, Locke and Rousseau on the social contract.

Suggested structure: Introduction and definition → Hobbes on insecurity and strong sovereignty → Locke on natural rights, consent and resistance → Rousseau on general will and popular sovereignty → similarities → differences → criticisms → conclusion.

Discuss Plato's concept of the ideal state.

Suggested structure: Define justice → explain harmony and functional classes → philosopher-kings → education → relation between individual and state → strengths → criticisms → conclusion.

Assess Marx's theory of the state.

Suggested structure: Define Marxism → historical materialism → class structure → economic power → state and class relations → revolution/class consciousness → later interpretations → criticisms → conclusion.

Discuss the meaning and importance of democracy.

Suggested structure: Define democracy → direct versus representative → participation → elections → accountability → rights and rule of law → majority/minority issue → challenges → conclusion.

Examine Rawls's theory of justice as fairness.

Suggested structure: Define justice → original position → veil of ignorance → equal basic liberties → fair equality of opportunity → difference principle → strengths → criticisms → conclusion.

Discuss the relationship between liberty and equality.

Suggested structure: Define both → negative/positive liberty → formal/substantive equality → arguments for compatibility → arguments about possible tensions → examples → balanced conclusion.

Evaluate the importance of constitutionalism in modern government.

Suggested structure: Define constitutionalism → limited government → rights → separation of powers → judicial review → accountability → possible weaknesses → conclusion.

Discuss the relevance of African political thought today.

Suggested structure: Define African political thought → Nkrumah → Nyerere → Fanon → Pan-Africanism → sovereignty/dependency → contemporary governance and development → limitations → conclusion.

Is civil disobedience ever justified?

Suggested structure: Define political obligation → define civil disobedience → reasons supporting it → conditions for responsible disobedience → objections → examples → reasoned conclusion.

Explain feminist criticisms of traditional political theory.

Suggested structure: Define feminist political theory → public/private divide → exclusion from traditional theory → liberal/radical/socialist/intersectional approaches → contributions → criticisms and responses → conclusion.

29. RAPID REVISION CHECKLIST

■ Can I define every key concept in one or two sentences?

■ Can I compare Hobbes, Locke and Rousseau without mixing their arguments?

■ Can I explain Plato and Aristotle separately and identify their differences?

■ Can I distinguish power, authority and legitimacy?

■ Can I explain negative and positive liberty?

■ Can I discuss Rawls and Nozick as contrasting theories of justice?

■ Can I explain Marxist class analysis?

■ Can I identify core features of democracy?

■ Can I explain constitutionalism and separation of powers?

■ Can I discuss feminist, nationalist and African political theories?

■ Can I give a relevant example for each major concept?

■ Can I construct an introduction, argument, criticism and conclusion for an essay?

FINAL EXAM TIP

Do not merely list points. Explain what each point means, connect it to a thinker or theory, provide an example, and evaluate it. Where a question says 'discuss', present more than one side. Where it says 'assess' or 'evaluate', make a clear judgment supported by reasons.